till we are out of this hellhole! Shoot your way through, and keep the b——ds' heads down'.

Stopping there would have been a grave mistake. The elaborately laid ambush was spread over 150 metres. As ordered, the troops carried on firing and fighting through the flak, mounted on their vehicles, as rehearsed by them many times. Once we were out of the killing area, I stopped and asked the men to quickly dismount from the vehicles and return fire from whatever cover they could find.

'Phew, that was indeed a close shave for all of us,' I remarked.

The ambush plan was immaculate; thought out in minute detail. The terrorist in the tea shop on the highway gave the early warning. The stops were deployed on both ends of the ambush point, and the firing party covered the killing zone effectively. The getaway routes were well reconnoitred and mock rehearsals carried out in advance. The ambush was to be sprung on the command of the leader. This was what was going to decide the success or failure of the mission. The timing had to be perfect.

Scene of Ambush – Tashkent Chowk, Baramulla, July 1992

'Get them! Don't let them escape', shouted the leader of the terrorists. He realized that he had delayed the signal to open fire by a few seconds. It was only because he wanted to be sure of getting his kill, and not act prematurely. However, he never anticipated the commander to be up ahead and leading the cavalcade.

'The commander is in the leading vehicle. He is in the jonga! Take him on with the machinegun, fire the RPG, bring down fire of all weapons, kill him, kill the b——d,' shouted the leader. The machine-gunner tried his best to execute the orders of his leader, but he couldn't aim at the jonga as by then, it was obscured by the 1-tonner. Frustrated, he emptied the whole magazine in a long burst through the truck, not sure if he had got his target. His colleague got excited and pressed the trigger of the rocket launcher but missed the jonga. He saw the rocket explode with a loud bang in the school playground which lay in the flight path beyond the intended target!

Realizing the futility of continuing with the action and the fact that his prey had gotten away this time too, the terrorist leader ordered his companions to abandon their positions and make good their escape as quickly as possible.